

Is water use per head low?

*Testing a public claim about Malta's per-person water use
against Eurostat's household series*

THE CLAIM UNDER REVIEW

***“Per capita water consumption, today
stands at around 110l/cap/day.”***

Manuel Sapiano, Energy and Water Agency, keynote slide, IWRA 1st Island Water Congress, 2024.
On a slide about keeping per-person consumption “low”.

VERDICT: LARGELY SUPPORTED

The figure is close; “low” is not benchmarked

Version 1.0 · 7 October 2026

Status: no right of reply needed

Prepared from public sources and Eurostat data.

Repository: github.com/leandergrech/Mizien

MIŻIEN · AN INDEPENDENT FACT-CHECKING PROJECT

Contest a verdict, with evidence: github.com/leandergrech/Mizien/issues

TL;DR

In a keynote to the 1st Island Water Congress (IWRA, 2024), Manuel Sapiano of the Energy and Water Agency showed a slide saying: **“Per capita water consumption, today stands at around 110l/cap/day.”** The previous slide says tariffs and engagement have “contributed to maintaining the per capita water consumption low”. We tested the figure against Eurostat’s household water-use series. It is close, but Eurostat’s estimate for Maltese households is higher, and Malta sits mid-table among the EU states that report. The keynote does not compare Malta with other countries; that framing came from the intake record, not from the speaker.

- 1

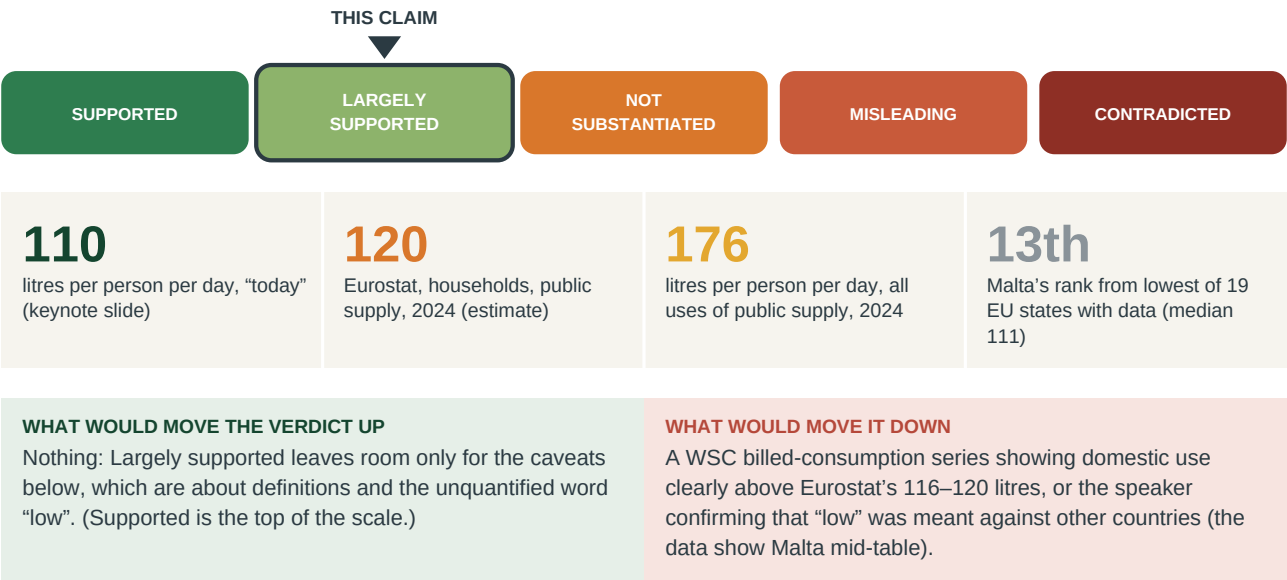
The figure is about right. Eurostat puts Maltese households’ use of public water at 116–120 litres per person per day in 2022–2024 (an estimate, 9% above 110 in 2024), against “around 110” in the keynote.
- 2

It covers households only. All uses of the public supply, including services such as hotels, come to about 169–176 litres per head per day on the same basis, because the supply also serves tourists, shops and industry.
- 3

“Low” is not shown by this comparison. Among the 19 EU states with a recent household figure, Malta ranks 13th from the lowest, 8% above the median (111 l). The speaker made no EU comparison, so this does not contradict the keynote.
- 4

The tariff effect is untested. We found no evidence on how much the rising block tariff changed use; we did not obtain the tariff schedule.
- 5

Verdict: largely supported (moderate confidence). The central figure agrees with Eurostat within about 10%. “Low” is a qualitative word that the keynote does not benchmark.



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1

The claim and what we could verify

The primary source is the slide deck of the keynote “Water Management in the Maltese Islands” by Manuel Sapiano, Energy and Water Agency, at the IWRA 1st Island Water Congress, 2024 [1]. We downloaded and read all 27 slides (the file is dated 15 October 2024). It is a slide deck, not a transcript: we cannot see what was said aloud. The wording we rate is on slide 10.

What the slide says	Who	Access
“Tariffs and a continuous engagement programme have contributed to maintaining the per capita water consumption low, and in the region of the 90 litres per person per day higher tariff threshold.”	E&WA keynote, slide 10 [1]	Read in full
“Per capita water consumption, today stands at around 110l/cap/day.”	E&WA keynote, slide 10 [1]	Read in full

WORDING NOTE

The claim record said the figure is “relatively low compared with other European countries”. We searched the whole deck for a comparison with other countries and found none: the only EU comparison on the slides is that Malta has “the highest population density in the EU” (slide 2). The comparative wording is therefore the intake’s paraphrase and is reported but not rated as the speaker’s claim. The deck does not say whether 110 litres is billed domestic consumption, supply per resident or another measure.

2

Method

Question. Is Maltese per-person water use about 110 litres a day, and is it low?

Evidence. Eurostat env_wat_cat (water use by supply category and sector, OECD/Eurostat Joint Questionnaire on Inland Waters; public water supply, households) and demo_pjan (population on 1 January) [2][3], retrieved 7 October 2026. Per-person use = households’ volume divided by the mean of the 1 January population of that year and the next, converted to litres per day. Every Maltese value is flagged as estimated by Eurostat. The calculation is `tools/cc-040-report/calc.py`; inputs and results are in `data/cc-040/`.

Grades. Official statistics are grade C; the speaker’s slide is grade D (an assertion without method or source).

Verdicts follow the five-point scale in Appendix A.

3

What the data show

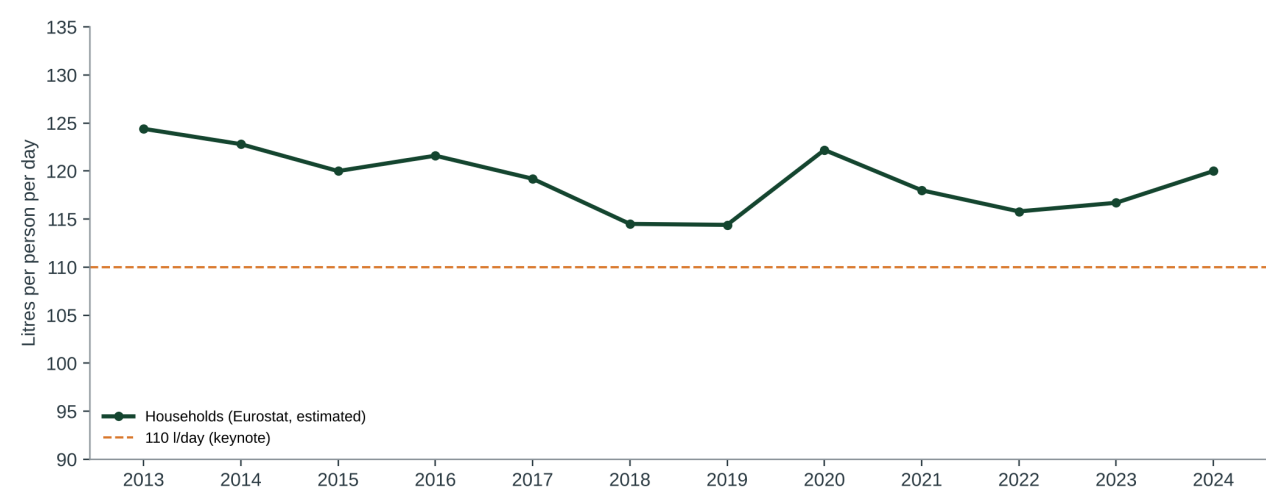


Figure 1. Maltese households' use of public water per person, 2013–2024, from Eurostat (all values flagged as estimated), against the keynote's 110 litres. The series has stayed between 114 and 124 litres and was 120 in 2024.

Indicator (Malta, public water supply)	2019	2022	2024	Grade
Households, litres per person per day	114	116	120	C
Services (incl. hotels), litres per head of resident population	42	39	40	C
All uses, litres per head of resident population	173	169	176	C
Households vs the keynote's 110	+4%	+5%	+9%	C

Values in data/cc-040/checks.csv. “All uses” divides all sectors’ use of the public supply by the resident population; it includes use by tourists and businesses, so it is not a per-resident consumption figure.

Malta among EU states

Eurostat has a recent household figure for 19 of the 27 Member States (Estonia, Finland, France, Ireland, Italy, Luxembourg, Portugal and Slovakia have none from 2020 on). Taking each state’s latest year (2020–2024; Spain and Sweden 2020, Belgium and Germany 2022), Malta’s 120 litres ranks 13th from the lowest and is 8% above the median of 111 litres (Figure 2). Latvia, Lithuania, Czechia, Belgium and Romania are below 90; Greece (220) and Cyprus (294) are far higher [2].

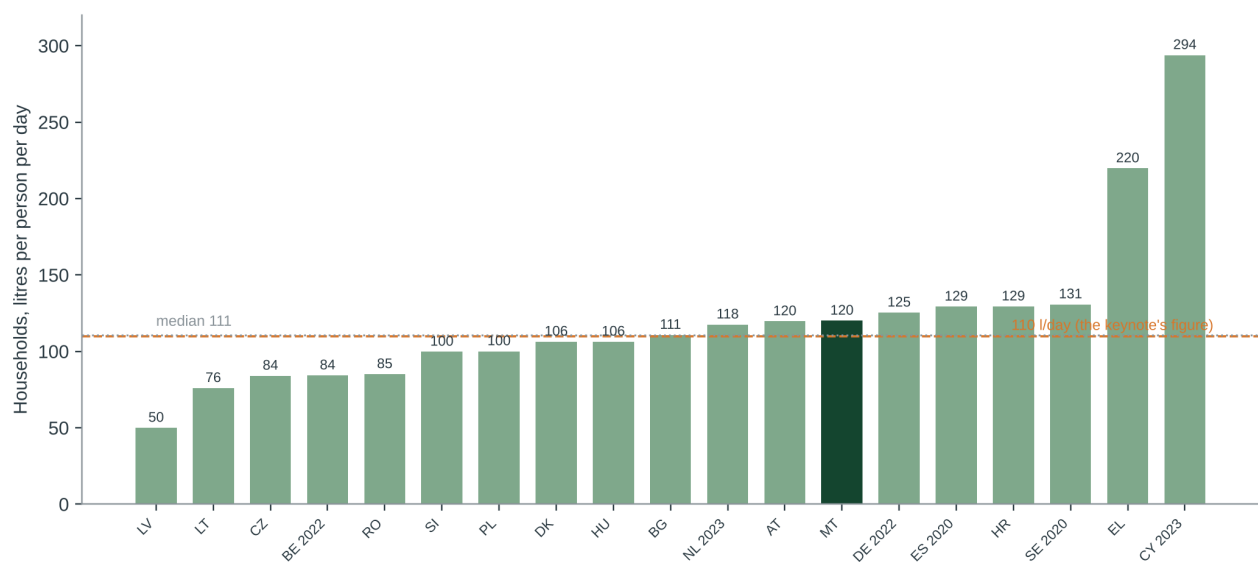


Figure 2. Households’ use of public water per person per day, latest year 2020–2024, EU states with data. Years differ between states (labelled where not 2024); definitions follow the Joint Questionnaire but national collection methods differ.

4

Where the evidence points different ways

Q1 Is consumption “around 110 litres”? CLOSE	
EVIDENCE FOR THE CLAIM’S IMPRESSION Eurostat’s household series (116 in 2022, 120 in 2024) is within about 5–9% of 110; “around” covers that, and the series was 114 in 2018–2019. The speaker’s figure may be billed domestic consumption, which we have not seen.	EVIDENCE AGAINST Every Maltese Eurostat value is an estimate, and the 2024 value is the highest since 2020. We did not obtain WSC billing data, so we cannot say which definition 110 follows.
WHY THEY DIFFER, AND WHAT IT MEANS HERE For this claim: the figure is a fair round number for households; a higher recent trend is not reflected.	
Q2 Is it “low”? NOT SHOWN	
EVIDENCE FOR THE CLAIM’S IMPRESSION On the keynote’s own terms the claim is about holding use down while the population and economy grew (slide 9). We did not test that history: the slide’s 350 litres in 1995 is production capacity per head, not consumption, so it is not comparable.	EVIDENCE AGAINST Against other EU states Malta is mid-table (13th of 19; 8% above the median). Total supply per resident, 176 litres, includes use by services and tourists.
WHY THEY DIFFER, AND WHAT IT MEANS HERE For this claim: “low” has no benchmark in the deck; against EU peers it is not low, but the speaker did not claim that.	

5

Testing the claim

Sub-claim	What the evidence shows	Rating
A. “Per capita water consumption, today stands at around 110l/cap/day”	Eurostat households: 116 (2022), 120 (2024), estimates [2][3]. Within about 9%; definition of the 110 not stated.	LARGELY SUPPORTED
B. Consumption has been kept “low”	No benchmark in the deck. Malta ranks 13th of 19 EU states, 8% above the median [2].	NOT SHOWN
C. Tariffs and engagement “contributed” to this; a “90 litres” higher-tariff threshold	A causal claim with no evidence in the deck; the WSC tariff schedule was not obtained.	NOT TESTED
D. “Relatively low compared with other European countries” (intake wording)	Not in the speaker’s words; headline wording, not rated. For reference, Malta is mid-table [2].	NOT RATED

6

Verdict and requests for evidence

VERDICT

LARGELY SUPPORTED

The figure is about right for households; “low” is unquantified. Confidence: moderate.

Why. (1) The headline number, 110 litres, is within about 9% of Eurostat’s household figure for 2024 and 5% for 2022. (2) The keynote gives no benchmark for “low” and no source for the 110, and the tariff effect is not evidenced, so we rate them as not shown rather than false. (3) The EU comparison in the claim record is not the speaker’s statement; we report it (Malta is mid-table) without rating it. Our scale calls backing with caveats that do not change the substance *Largely supported*.

What this verdict does not say. It does not say that Malta’s water use is low by European standards or that its water supply is sustainable. The keynote itself says natural freshwater is insufficient even at highly efficient demand (slide 3).

Evidence we are asking for

- ☐ The source and definition of the 110 litres figure (billed domestic, per resident, year).
- ☐ WSC domestic billed consumption and the resident population used, 2015–2024.
- ☐ The rising block tariff schedule and any estimate of its effect on use.

7

Limitations

- We read slides only: any spoken qualification is not in the deck.
- Eurostat’s Maltese values are estimates; its metadata page for the dataset family (env_nwat_esms) refers to the Joint Questionnaire definitions, which we did not read in full.
- Eurostat’s per-person figure uses our population denominator (mean of two 1 January populations); WSC may use another.
- EU comparison covers 19 states with different years (2020–2024); countries differ in how they measure household use. Greece and Cyprus are very high, so we use the median.
- We did not search WSC or NSO publications for a 110 litres series; none was found through Eurostat or in our web search of 7 October 2026 (see literature/CC-040/notes.md).

References

- [1] Sapiano M. (2024). Water Management in the Maltese Islands. Keynote, IWRA 1st Island Water Congress. Energy and Water Agency (slide deck, 27 slides).
https://www.iwra.org/proceedings/congress/resource/IWRA2024_1stIslandWC_0609_HLP_EuroInbo_MSapiano_Keynote.pdf
- [2] Eurostat. env_wat_cat, Water use by supply category and economical sector (public water supply, households; status flags checked); retrieved 7 Oct 2026. https://doi.org/10.2908/ENV_WAT_CAT
- [3] Eurostat. demo_pjan, Population on 1 January by age and sex; retrieved 7 Oct 2026. https://doi.org/10.2908/DEMO_PJAN
- [4] Eurostat. Environment and water statistics, explanatory texts (env_nwat_esms).
https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/cache/metadata/en/env_nwat_esms.htm
- [5] MiŻien. Data and calculations: data/cc-040/; tools/cc-040-report/calc.py.

Appendix A: series standards and verdict scale

Every investigation in this series follows the same rules so that verdicts are comparable and challengeable.

Verdict	Meaning
SUPPORTED	Evidence consistently backs the claim as stated.
LARGELY SUPPORTED	Backed by the evidence, with minor caveats that do not change the substance.
NOT SUBSTANTIATED	Stated more strongly than the evidence offered or available allows. May be true in some conditions but has not been shown.
MISLEADING	Omits material facts so that the overall impression is inaccurate, even if individual statements are defensible.
CONTRADICTED	The available evidence points against the claim.

Confidence

High: multiple independent lines of evidence agree. **Moderate:** evidence is relevant but incomplete or indirect. **Low:** evidence is thin, second-hand or conflicting.

Evidence grades

A experiment · B observational study with a control or gradient · C review, guidance or official statistics · D assertion or anecdote. ♦ marks a source known only second-hand.

Standards

- **Quote the speaker, not the headline**, with outlet and date, and link the original where possible.
- **Separate the claim from the evidence offered for it**, and say who made which statement.
- **Grade the evidence** and show differing views side by side where the evidence is unsettled.
- **State what we could not access or verify**, and what would change the verdict either way.
- **Ask for the missing evidence** in specific, answerable requests.
- **Offer a right of reply** where a check finds a claim Not substantiated, Misleading or Contradicted (or a pledge Not measurable, Off track or Missed), before wider circulation, and append responses.
- **Correct errors openly** with a version number and change log.
- **Whistle-blow only on evidence:** a verdict of *Misleading* or *Contradicted* requires documents or data that can be shown, not inference.
- **Check every side.** Government, opposition, NGOs and developers are held to the same standard.

Appendix B: revision log

Version	Date	Change
1.0	7 Oct 2026	First issue. No right of reply needed.